

8. **Scalability:** Last but not the least, one must be sure about how easily the solution is scalable to the future needs of the organisation.

Open source backup solutions

The industry is full of proprietary or, rather, commercial backup solutions. The open source world, too, has evolved in leaps and bounds to provide hundreds of cost-effective and easily available alternatives, designed to cater to every possible need of an industry.

Some of these are *Amanda*, *Areca Backup*, *BackupPC*, *Bacula*, *Duplicity*, *Zamanda Recovery Manager*...and the list goes on. All of these specialise in the backup requirements of particular industries.

So, are open source backup solutions industry-ready?

My answer would be that, yes, they are. The table given below shows how open source solutions measure up against the characteristics of an ideal backup solution.

Property	Open source backup solution
Versatility	Most often, open source software is compatible across devices and platforms. In some cases, even if it cannot be used directly, there are always means to use the solution on an unsupported platform (Cygwin being an example for Windows).
Ease of use	Initially, open source solutions may seem difficult to master but since the development of any open source software is a collaborative effort involving people from various geographies and backgrounds, this automatically translates into software that's easy to use and master, for all.
Documentation	As the term 'open source' suggests, documentation and knowledge about the software will never be a worry.
Cost factor	The most important advantage of adopting an open source solution is cost. Open source solutions are either available free or for a negligible cost, when compared with other proprietary commercial products.
Quick and reliable recovery	Depending on the requirements of the business, the open source world provides different backup solutions that cater to the various needs of businesses for quick recovery with zero or minimal downtime.
Backup security	All industry level backup solutions use the latest and most effective security and encryption methods to keep backed up data safe. Various logging, time stamping and encryption methods are used to keep track of the access and use of backed up data.
Scalability	A solution's ability to scale with the growing needs of the business depends more on the design fundamentals of the specific product, rather than whether it is open source or proprietary. Having said that, open source backup solutions do provide an option to use either local or network based backup storage. That enables the solution to scale up in accordance with the needs of the business.
Support	One of the biggest selling points used for proprietary solutions against open source solutions is 'phone call support', which basically provides support from a single person of contact on the solutions provider's side. The flipside of this is that the support available will be limited to what that one person knows since not many individuals would have expertise on the 'complete design, implementation, user scenario and debugging details of the product'. In the open source world, the first line of support is at the user's finger tips, i.e., the World Wide Web. More often than not, people with expert knowledge of the product and technology are easily accessible through IRCs and mailing lists. Also, if businesses really need accountable support, almost all the open source backup solutions do have commercial licences, which come with various kinds of support options at a cost that's much lower than proprietary backup solutions.

References

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